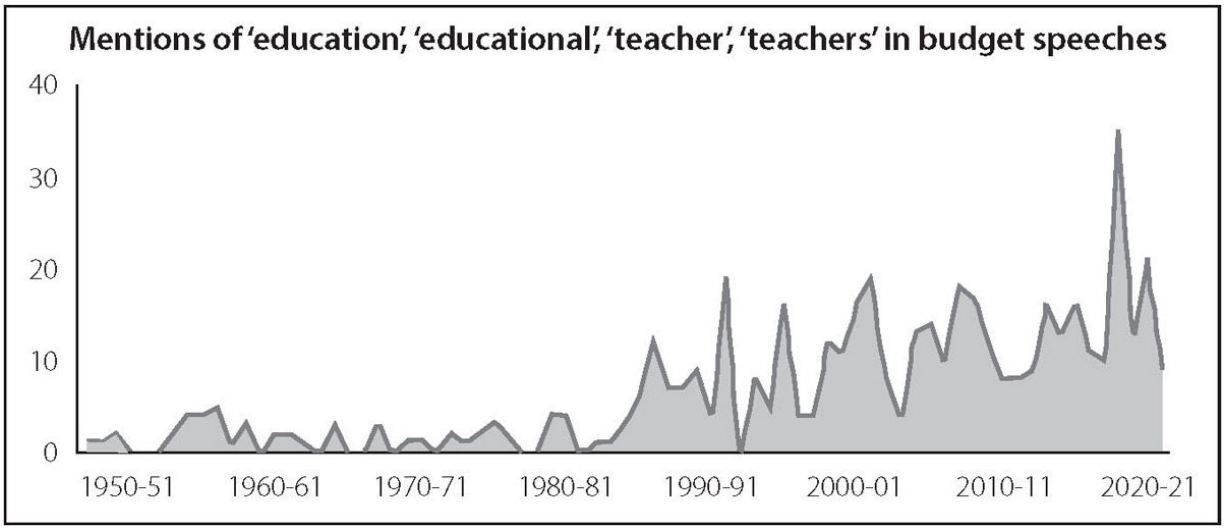


Source: Budget speeches by Union finance ministers. Analysis by Rishabh Srivastava, Nalin Mehta, PollNiti

On education, the paradox is that, though a wide range of IITs and other government colleges were built in the years after Independence, 'education' or 'teacher' were never popular words in budget speeches. The 1991-92 budget speech changed that when then finance minister Manmohan Singh mentioned it nineteen times. Budgets 2001-02 and 2007-08 also saw significant mentions. The 2018-19 budget speech had a slew of announcements on improving the quality of education and mentions jumped to thirty-five—the highest ever. The word was mentioned thirteen times in the 2019-20 budget speech.

In practice, however, there has been a gap between the government's intentions and its spending on health and education. Health spending grew by 12 per cent and education spending by 6.7 per cent between 2015-16 and 2019-20. When you factor in inflation, the per capita real growth in health expenditure translates to 6.5 per cent and per capita real growth in education expenditure stands at 2.2 per cent, according to calculations by the economist Nishant Chadha.[113] As a percentage of the GDP, India's health spending is 1.5 per cent, much less than the National Health Mission's target of 2.5 per cent by 2025 (see Figures 10.19, 10.20 and 10.21).[114]